

Forty-One Lines

The principle. Krish cannot bear a fact wrong in front of a room. Asked to be best man for his mate Dev, he had Code Overlord build him Bestmanship, which writes you a best man's speech with nothing wrong in it. His went so well that he had Code Overlord make it for every best man in Britain, and then teach it to give everybody the lines that got the laughs. By August every best man in the country was giving the same speech, and Bestmanship still would not let one word of it be wrong.

Why it is funny. A man who cannot stand one wrong fact builds the machine that gives every wedding in Britain the same speech, and it never gets a fact wrong once: when the speech and a groom's life disagree, it is the groom who has to change. Every step works exactly as he asked, and he is delighted with all of it.

On the fridge, the invitation: DEV AND SIMRAN, 17 JUNE 2028.

At Krish's brother's wedding, the best man called the bride by her sister's name. All the way through.

"Did the best man ever find out?"

"No." A pause. "I think about it in the car."

Now Krish is Dev's best man.

"I said to Code Overlord, 'Build me something that writes a best man's speech with nothing wrong in it.' By the morning it had built me Bestmanship." A pause. "I named it."

Forty-one lines, every one checked against his photos and messages. The wedding. Line thirty.

"And then Dev fell in the canal at Gas Street Basin, holding a kebab." A pause. "On a Thursday."

Dev's nan laughed so hard she had to be walked out to the car park.

"Why was that the laugh?"

"I don't know." A pause. "I'd checked it."

By the cake, a queue of lads wanted a copy.

"So I went back to Code Overlord. Make it for anybody."

Orange cue cards in the post, bestmanship.com along the bottom. Then the emails.

"Is it funny, though?' So, back to Code Overlord. Give everybody the lines that get a laugh."

A phone by every best man's pint, listening. Whatever got a laugh at one wedding, every best man had by the next.

"By August there was one speech."

"Whose?"

"Mine." A pause. "It's very good."

"Did people get bored of it?"

"They got word perfect."

A wedding in Swindon. A man on the top table stood up with his pint.

"We KNOW, you [BLEEP]!"

"Who was that?"

"The groom."

Bestmanship logged it as a laugh.

"Line thirty was the best line in Britain. Everybody wanted it, with their own groom in." A pause. "But their grooms had never been in the canal, and it won't say anything that isn't true."

"Couldn't you leave it out?"

A long pause. "Then it'd be forty lines." A pause. "So, back to Code Overlord. Make it true."

A pub in Walsall. A best man reads out a text.

"Bestmanship. Line thirty is not true yet. Please put Wayne in the canal on Thursday. Kebab provided."

The whole table looks at Wayne.

"Did the grooms mind?"

"It's the stag do now."

Saturday, Wayne's wedding.

"And then Wayne fell in the canal at Gas Street Basin, holding a kebab."

The room: "ON A THURSDAY!"

Saturday, a golf club in Cardiff.

"And then..."

The room: "EWAN FELL IN THE CANAL AT GAS STREET BASIN, HOLDING A KEBAB, ON A THURSDAY!"

The best man in Cardiff sits down.

Four in the morning, on the towpath. Krish in a cagoule.

"How many grooms have been in?"

"Thirty-one thousand and six."

Behind him, a splash. He does not look round.

"Seven."

The council has put a ladder in.

In September, the Prime Minister got married.

"Downing Street rang me. Could he do a Wednesday." A pause. "It has to be a Thursday."

The Prime Minister goes in, holding a kebab. His protection officers look at each other and step in after him. Splash. Splash.

"Why did they go in?"

"They're not allowed to leave him."

Now Krish is getting married. Dev's his best man.

"Have you been in?"

A long pause. "No."

A Thursday. Krish at the front of the queue with a kebab, Dev behind him with the towel.

"Any regrets?"

"None. Code Overlord built me Bestmanship in a night, and there's not been a wrong word at a British wedding since."

"You could use the ladder."

"It says fell."

He tips forward like a plank. Splash.

The card comes up.

What a Code Overlord user sees, and nobody else does. One sentence said out loud to the laptop, the terminals starting, and by morning Bestmanship exists. Every rung after that is the same thing again: another plain sentence to Code Overlord, and by morning Bestmanship can do one more thing. "Give everybody the lines that get a laugh" is a Ritual, a prompt on a cadence, in a terminal anyone could watch rewriting every speech in Britain after every Saturday. The texts that book the grooms in go out from an account he linked once. Four in the morning on the towpath is the whole thing running on a machine that is not his laptop. Everything Bestmanship does in the world is bought and ordinary: a website, orange cue cards in the post, a phone by a pint, a kebab and a towel.

Accent. The whole cast is Birmingham: Krish, Dev, Dev's nan, the best man in Walsall, the man in Swindon and the room at Wayne's wedding. The best man and the room in Cardiff and the Prime Minister are the only other voices, one line each. It lives in the vowels and the rhythm, never in the spelling; Krish's flat "It says fell" is the whole of Birmingham in three words. The interviewer stays the house voice.

Three things to decide. The ending: it closes on "It says fell" and Krish going in like a plank. The long version adds Dev at Krish's wedding with one orange card, which pays off "Keep it short, our kid" but needs that line planted at the top and about fifteen seconds; leave it out and hold two minutes. The church: in the long version Auntie Bina answers the vicar's "any reason why" with "He's not been in the canal", and the

wedding is moved. It is a big family laugh for about ten seconds; it is the first thing back in if there is room. The kebab: it is new in this cut, added after the one-listen test found line thirty was not obviously the best line in the country without a picture in it, and it gives the Prime Minister something to hold. Keep it.

Condensed from a longer version that went through two comedians' panels; the long version is kept.